



FOOD FOR THOUGHT

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The invisible deficit

The reality of **food intolerance** is that it interferes with recovery, increases inflammation, and indirectly impacts heart rate, metabolism, and performance output.

The human gut is central to athletic performance. It is not just about digestion; it is about nutrient absorption, immune function, and even mental clarity. When athletes consume a food they are intolerant to, the gut lining becomes irritated. This leads to compromised absorption of key nutrients like iron, magnesium, and B vitamins. Over time, this creates deficiencies even when the diet looks perfect on paper. The athlete feels tired, recovery slows down, and performance plateaus.

This gut disruption doesn't stop at digestion. Another overlooked consequence is systemic inflammation. This is not the visible swelling you see after an injury; it is internal inflammation that affects muscles, joints, and connective tissues. It increases the risk of injuries and delays healing. Athletes might follow the best recovery protocol in the world, but if their daily nutrition is triggering inflammation, they are fighting a losing battle.

I remember a case that reinforced this deeply. A young tennis player in her late teens came to me. She was disciplined, hardworking, and doing everything right on paper. She was also consuming whey protein regularly, which, for her as a vegetarian, was a key source supporting her recovery and muscle development under a demanding training schedule. However, her mother reported something concerning. The girl slept with her mouth open, her nose was constantly blocked, and every morning she would wake up with thick mucus. The early part of her day was spent sneezing and clearing her nasal passages before her breathing normalised.

When she joined my programme, I asked her to

undergo a food intolerance test. The results were surprising. She was intolerant to all forms of dairy, including lactose, casein, and even the fat component of milk. Whey protein, which she depended on heavily, was actually working against her body. We immediately removed it from her diet. Naturally, there was concern because this was her primary protein source. I shifted her to brown rice protein, as she was also intolerant to green pea protein, which is commonly used in plant blends.

Within three weeks, the changes were clear. Her nasal congestion reduced significantly. She was able to breathe better through the night and sleep more deeply. We also observed improvements in her resting heart rate and nighttime respiration. The most important outcome came on the court. She became noticeably faster and quicker because her recovery had improved through better sleep and reduced inflammation.

This is the reality of food intolerance. It does not just affect digestion. It interferes with recovery, increases inflammation, and indirectly impacts heart rate, metabolism, and performance